PHUCHKA WARS





This Durga Puja, Bengal's fiercest battle wasn't ideological, it was edible. TMC's **Abhishek Banerjee** set the tone on Ashtami, queueing up at a roadside stall with daughter, popping phuchkas and posing for the perfect "jhal-mishti" moment. Not to be out-snacked, BJP's **Suvendu Adhikari** soon followed suit, seen gleefully gulping the same street-side delicacy. What else says son-of-the-soil better than a phuchka or two, and attract votes for this show of rootedness.

SUN SCREEN



On a recent trip to Mysuru, Karnataka CM **Siddaramaiah** let on that a new house he is building in the city (incidentally also his hometown) will be ready by December. The previous one had apparently been sold to clear a loan. When local reporters asked if the new residence would have suitable arrangements for reporters so that they don't have to wait in the sun as they do now, Sidda quipped: "It has a cellar downstairs, there's ample shade there."

CALM VS THE STORM





As **Vijay**'s roadshow in Karur spiralled into tragedy and cast a shadow over his political debut, the original superstar of Tamil cinema was on a very different stage. **Rajinikanth**, who once stirred hopes of political change only to retreat, is now on a spiritual sojourn in the Himalayas. The contrast couldn't be starker: Vijay grappling with the chaos of crowds, Rajini basking in the solitude and serenity of the mountains.

Kaushik Deka with Rahul Noronha, Jeemon Jacob, Arkamoy Datta Majumdar, Ajay Sukumaran and Kavitha Muralidharan

ECO WATCH

By **Rahul Noronha**

TRANSLOCATING PREY ANIMALS
CHOPPERS FOR THE ROUND-UP

In a first-of-its-kind operation, helicopters will now be used to corral and capture herbivorous wildlife for translocation purposes. The Madhya Pradesh forest department has finalised South Africa-based Conservation Solutions for carrying out the helicopter-based operation. At the most basic level, South African chopper pilots who have experience of carrying out such ops, will lead it in India. The Madhya Pradesh forest department has identified Shajapur, Agar Malwa and Ujjain districts in the western part of the state to capture blackbuck and nilgai (blue bulls). The operation will commence in 2-3 weeks as it'll be the lean season agriculture-wise—the fields will be without crops, making capture easier. The SA pilots will be assisted by their Indian counterparts, who will get to acquire the requisite experience in carrying out the operation.

The antelopes would be driven using the helicopters into bomas or enclosures from where they would be loaded into trucks and transported to the Kuno Palpur National Park and Gandhi Sagar Sanctuary and released. Both reserves are home to the cheetahs in MP and would augment the prey base.



In the first round, 500 blackbucks and 100 nilgai are to be captured. The translocation operation would not just augment the prey base but also reduce crop damage by these animals in the fields. MP farmers have long demanded that they be allowed to cull these animals since they are a menace, but have been met with silence so far.